

Count pawn races in plies

Chess Math

THE IDEA

A ply is one player's move. A full move usually contains two plies. Comparing promotion races only by the number of pushes can be misleading because the first promotion may arrive with check and interrupt the other side.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Each side has a pawn one step from promotion. If White moves first and queens with check, Black may have to answer the check instead of promoting. Equal push counts do not imply simultaneous queens.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

What three details should you add to a pawn-race count?

ANSWER AND REASONING

Who moves first, whether either promotion gives check, and whether the new piece can stop the rival pawn. Also inspect captures and blocked promotion squares.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

Count forcing effects as well as running distance.